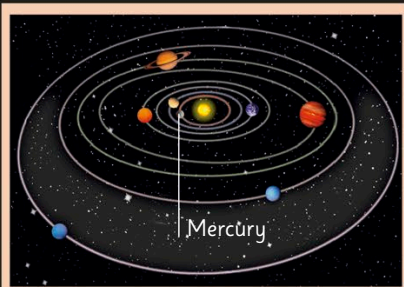


Mercury

The closest planet to the Sun, and far smaller than the Earth, Mercury has blistering hot days, but freezing nights. The nights get cold because Mercury has no atmosphere to trap the Sun's heat.



It takes 88 days for Mercury to orbit the Sun. So, it has the shortest year of all the planets in the solar system.

Surface mapping

In 1974 and 1975, the space probe *Mariner 10* flew within 327 km (203 miles) of Mercury's surface. It took hundreds of photographs, covering just under half the planet.

An easy target

Mariner 10 provided close-ups of Mercury that showed a heavily scarred surface. Rather like the Earth's moon, this planet was battered by asteroids long ago. It is covered with bowl-shaped hollows, called craters, where the asteroids hit. The surface has hardly changed in the last billion years.

weird or what?

One of Mercury's craters (the Caloris Basin) is so large that the British Isles could fit comfortably into it.

Many of Mercury's craters are named after famous painters, authors, and musicians, such as Mozart, Beethoven, Michelangelo, and Bach.